UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART I: JOB READINESS

TOPIC 6: POSITIVE WORKING RELATIONSHIPS

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand how to develop and maintain positive working relationships
- Understand the importance of positive behavior in producing positive effects
- Understand how to give and receive feedback in a professional way

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Complete a positive behavior exercise
- Participate in a group exercise and a team challenge to practice developing positive working relationships

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Group Exercise: Alone and Together
From http://www.thiagi.com/pfp/IE4H/november2007.html#ControlGroups

Objective: Students will explore the advantages and disadvantages of working in teams and working independently.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "How to Solve a Mini Sudoku Puzzle," "First Sudoku: Solve in Teams," "First Sudoku: Solve Alone," "First Sudoku: Solution," "Second Sudoku: Solve in Teams," "Second Sudoku: Solve Alone," "Second Sudoku: Solution," pencils with erasers, stopwatch

- Participants are divided into an even number of teams. During the first round, some teams solve a sudoku puzzle jointly while members of the other teams solve it individually. During the second round, teams solve another sudoku puzzle, reversing the joint and individual approaches.
- Distribute copies of "How To Solve Mini Sudoku Puzzles." Pause while participants read the handout. Answer any questions.
- Form an even number of teams (2, 4, 6, 8, 10, etc.), each with two to seven participants.
- Give the "First Sudoku: Solve in Teams" handout to one half of the teams. Each team should receive a single copy of the handout to require team members to work together. Ask the teams to work jointly and solve the puzzle.
- Give the "First Sudoku: Solve Alone" handout to the remaining teams. Each team member should receive a personal copy of the handout to solve the puzzle independently. Ask team members not to talk to each other and solve the puzzle independently.
- Announce a 3-minute time limit for solving the puzzle. At the end of this time, blow a whistle and ask everyone to stop solving the puzzle. Distribute copies of the solution.
- After a short pause, ask each participant to write down a number from 1 to 5 to indicate her reaction to the puzzle solving experience. Explain that "1" stands for a very negative reaction (including frustration or boredom) and "5" for a very positive reaction (including enthusiasm and a feeling of achievement). Participants can write this number on a corner of the solution sheet. Team participants can write their number on a separate piece of paper.
- Identify the teams that received the independent-solving handout during the previous round and give each team a single copy of the "Second Sudoku: Solve in Teams" handout. Ask members of each team to work jointly and solve the problem.
- Identify the teams that received the team-solving handout during the previous round and give each member of these teams a copy of the "Second Sudoku: Solve Alone" handout. Explain that each team member should solve the puzzle independently.
- As before, announce a 3-minute time limit for solving the puzzle. At the end of this time, blow a whistle and ask everyone to stop solving the puzzle. Distribute copies of the solution.
- As before, ask each participant to write down a number from 1 to 5 to indicate her reaction to the second puzzle solving experience.

Debriefing Questions:

- Was your reaction to working alone different from your reaction to working in a team?
- Why do you think people have different reactions to working alone and working in a team?
- Why would some people prefer teamwork to independent work? Why would others have the opposite preference?
- What are the advantages of teamwork? What are the advantages of independent work?
- In which situations would you prefer to use teamwork? Independent work?
- If you were an expert sudoku puzzle solver, how would you feel about working in a team? Working alone?
- If you were a newcomer to solving sudoku puzzles, how would you feel about working in a team? Working alone?

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will understand hot to develop and maintain positive working relationships.
Time: 15 minutes
Materials: Handout: **"Developing and Maintaining Good Working Relationships,"** flipchart and markers, stickers

Explain to students that even if they would rather work alone, being able to develop and maintain positive working relationships is very important. Ask students why this is so important at work. Discuss the importance of working well with others.

Ask students to brainstorm ways to develop and maintain positive working relationships. Capture what they say on flipchart. Once they have added all of their ideas to the list, give everyone five stickers and ask them to vote on the five ideas that they feel are the most important. Once everyone has voted, circle the top ten ideas (determined by stickers). Hand out **"Developing and Maintaining Good Working Relationships."** Check with the group to see if there are any important ideas missing from the handout or from the list they created. Have students circle the things they currently do.

Small Group Exercise

Objective: Students will better understand the importance of positive behavior in producing positive effects.
Time: 15 minutes
Materials: Handout: **"Positive Behavior Exercise,"** pens/pencils

Instead of trying to unravel the secrets of the karmic universe or the meaning of religious and spiritual life, we can perhaps understand better the effects of our own positive behavior (or that of a group or entire corporation) by considering how we personally respond to the positive behavior of others.

Ask students to independently complete the **"Positive Behavior Exercise."** After about five minutes, divide students into small groups to discuss their answers. Post some questions for the groups to discuss:

- Discuss your responses to the different behaviors with your group.
- How do these behaviors relate to developing and maintaining positive working relationships?
- How do these behaviors connect to customer service and building working relationships with customers? Why is this important?
- Are positive behaviors always recognized? Do they always produce positive effects?
- Look back at the handout, and think about how you would feel or respond to: someone who rarely smiles and is generally unhappy, only gives to get something, never says thank you, blames others for everything, etc.
- Are negative behaviors more likely to produce negative effects? Why or Why not?
- Over time, which behaviors will most likely produce positive effects?

Positive behavior is sometimes described using the analogy of ripples from a pebble thrown into a pond — the effects radiate far and wide, and one day reflect back in ways that are difficult to predict beforehand, or to measure afterwards. Positive behavior in an organization could be compared to hundreds of pebbles in a pond every day.

Millions of people believe strongly that goodness and positivity are more likely to be rewarded in life than selfishness and negativity. And almost without exception, successful, happy people seem to exhibit and aspire to positive behaviors. The exercise should confirm how positively we each respond to positive behavior (and negatively to negative behavior). It's far simpler than karma.

Rather than try to find vast universal explanations for the way positive behavior works, the cause/effect of positive behavior is perhaps more easily explained by the general tendency for positive/giving behavior simply and **inevitably** to attract and to generate positive responses, somehow, somewhere, sometime.

Large Group Activity

Objective: Students will understand how to give and receive feedback professionally.

Time: 25 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Feedback,"** Feedback Definitions on Flipchart, paper, pens/pencils

Ask students what feedback at work is? Explain that the definition we are going to use for today's discussion and activity is: *The communication of information to an employee/co-worker/supervisor with the goal of reinforcing positive behaviors while also enabling adjustments for future behaviors to be made as necessary to improve work performance.*
Adapted from **http://www.businessdictionary.com/definition/feedback.html** &
http://dictionary.bnet.com/definition/Feedback.html

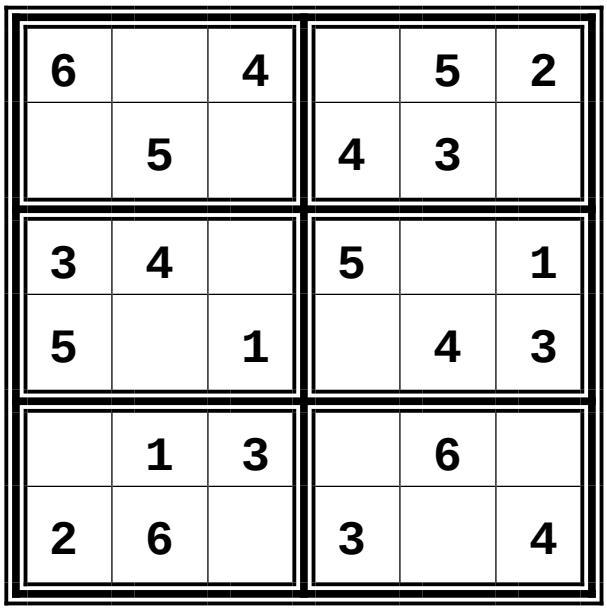
Divide the students into three groups. Assign each group one of the following topics: *From Supervisor to Employee, From Employee to Supervisor, From Co-worker to Co-worker.* Ask each group to create five scenarios describing specific situations where someone would need to provide feedback at work — for the relationship the group has been assigned. For example, if Group One is assigned From Supervisor to Employee, the group could create a scenario where a customer complained that one of the cashiers at a grocery store was rude and unprofessional. The cashier answered his phone while he was checking the woman out and had an unprofessional conversation while we has ringing her items up.

After the groups create the scenarios, collect them. Hand out **"Feedback"** and read through it with the large group. Discuss the Do's and Don'ts of Giving and Receiving Feedback. Pair students up and pass out one of the scenarios created earlier to each pair. Have them create two role-plays for the situation: one where the feedback is not given or received in a professional way, and the other where the feedback is given and received in a professional way. Discuss the role-plays, and point out where students used the tips from **"Feedback."**

How To Solve a Mini Sudoku Puzzle

You have probably seen sudoku puzzles in newspapers, magazines, books, and websites. Most sudoku puzzles use a 9 x 9 grid. In this learning activity, however, we will use mini-sudoku puzzles with 6 x 6 grids.

Here's a mini-sudoku puzzle. Notice that this 6 x 6 grid is divided into six rectangular 2 x 3 blocks. Some of the squares already contain numbers.



6		4		5	2
	5		4	3	
3	4		5		1
5		1		4	3
	1	3		6	
2	6		3		4

The challenge

Fill the empty squares of the grid above using the numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, and 6.

Each of the six numbers should appear only once in

- each row (six horizontal squares from left to right)
- each column (six vertical squares from top to bottom)
- each block (the 2 x 3 rectangles surrounded by thick lines).

The solution

Check the solution below. Verify that each row, column, and block contains the numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, and 6 once and only once.

6	3	4	1	5	2
1	5	2	4	3	6
3	4	6	5	2	1
5	2	1	6	4	3
4	1	3	2	6	5
2	6	5	3	1	4

First Sudoku: Solve Alone

Here's a mini-sudoku puzzle.

Solve this puzzle by yourself. Do not talk to anyone else.

5	3		4		
4				2	3
3	1		2	6	4
6	2	4		3	5
1	5				2
		6		5	1

First Sudoku: Solve in Teams

Here's a mini-sudoku puzzle.

Work with the other members of your team to solve the puzzle.

5	3		4		
4				2	3
3	1		2	6	4
6	2	4		3	5
1	5				2
		6		5	1

First Sudoku: Solution

5	3	2	4	1	6
4	6	1	5	2	3
3	1	5	2	6	4
6	2	4	1	3	5
1	5	3	6	4	2
2	4	6	3	5	1

Second Sudoku: Solve Alone

Here's a mini-sudoku puzzle.

Solve this puzzle by yourself. Do not talk to anyone else.

			4	3	1
4	1		5	6	
1			3	2	6
3	6	2			4
	3	1		4	5
2	5	4			

Second Sudoku: Solve in Teams

Here's a mini-sudoku puzzle.

Work with the other members of your team to solve the puzzle.

			4	3	1
4	1		5	6	
1			3	2	6
3	6	2			4
	3	1		4	5
2	5	4			

Second Sudoku: Solution

5	2	6	4	3	1
4	1	3	5	6	2
1	4	5	3	2	6
3	6	2	1	5	4
6	3	1	2	4	5
2	5	4	6	1	3

Developing and Maintaining Good Working Relationships

To Form New Relationships:

- Introduce yourself, so you know the person's name.
- Say hello and be friendly
- Get to know the person before you ask personal questions or tell personal things about yourself
- Respect people's personal space

To Improve Relationships With Co-Workers or Team Members:

- Make every effort to get to know your co-workers and the individuals they are
- Spend time talking during breaks and after work.
- Understand the importance of people having friends outside of work
- Never hang around when you are off and that person is still working
- Be proactive in your communication
- Follow through on what you promise
- Make every effort to resolve conflicts quickly and completely
- When people share information in confidence, keep it confidential! Be loyal to your team or work group

To Improve Your Relationship with Your Supervisor:

- Keep your Word
- Be Flexible
- Take Initiative
- Stay Focused on Your Work
- Communicate Effectively and Regularly
- Take Responsibility for Mistakes
- Learn to Work Independently
- Demonstrate Appropriate Behaviors
- Show Respect
- Do Your Best
- Maintain Professional Boundaries
- Be Positive
- Say Thanks for Recognition

Adapted From Professional Training Systems, Inc.
East Baltimore Pipeline Job Readiness Training Curriculum Page 134

Positive Behavior Exercise

Complete the chart by thinking about and writing how you feel about and respond to someone who behaves in the following ways:

1. Smiles a lot and is generally happy	
2. Gives to others and wants nothing in return	
3. Thanks others	
4. Helps others	
5. Listens to others without judging	
6. Takes the blame or responsibility for faults	
7. Gives others credit for successes	
8. Absorbs negative behavior from others with tolerance and understanding	

http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#team-building-games-exercises-activities

Feedback

Giving Feedback

DO'S

1. Describe the person's behavior that bothers you. "It bothers me when you finish my sentences for me."
2. Talk to the person right when things come up. Don't wait until things are likely to have been forgotten.
3. Use "I" messages. Own your feelings. "I feel bad when you finish my sentences for me."
4. Check for clarity. "Do you understand what I mean when I say that?"
5. Give consequences if behavior continues. "If you keep interrupting me, I most likely won't want to spend time talking with you in the future."
6. Only bring up behaviors that the person can do something about.
7. Be ready to listen to the other person's point of view.

DON'TS

1. Don't accuse the person. "You always interrupt me."
2. Don't bring in third parties. "John also says that you interrupt a lot."
3. Don't take for granted that the person understands what you are saying.
4. Don't give vague consequences. "That kind of behavior is going to get you in trouble."
5. Don't bring up behaviors that the person can't help. "The way you breathe really bothers me."
6. Don't deny the other person's feelings.

Receiving Feedback

Tips on receiving feedback...

1. Listen to the feedback without getting defensive.
2. Do not blindly accept what you are told as the ultimate truth.
3. Paraphrase the feedback to make sure that you understand correctly what is being said to you.
4. Remember that all feedback is helpful, because it gives you a chance to see how others view your work.
5. Follow through on the areas of improvement that are discussed.

Adapted From Professional Training Systems, Inc.
East Baltimore Pipeline Job Readiness Training Curriculum Page 159-160

More Activities to Practice Working Together (Optional)

Keypunch

A powerful exercise for learning how to work together, communicate and seek to improve performance in medium-sized groups.

Randomly lay out up to 30 numbered markers or spots in a set area. This forms the keypad.

Create a starting/finish point up to 10 yards beyond the set area — the group must assemble here — hence, they do not have clear view of the keypad either before the first attempt or in between attempts.

Briefing: The group must touch all the numbered spots as fast as they can. The team is given five attempts and must complete all attempts within a 30 minute window, whilst seeking to A. complete the task, and B. if possible, better their time. The group is penalized when a number is touched out of order and if more than one person is inside the boundary of the set area. The penalty may be, for example, that the group must start the attempt again but the time keeps ticking for that attempt.

Give the team 5 minutes to plan, then begin the 30-minute count down, and then start the timer for the first attempt. Time each attempt when they say they are ready to begin the next one.

The team will eventually arrive at a variety of solutions including giving each member of the team a number (or several numbers) to step on in sequence as they run through the set area. After several attempts this 'ordering' will become more fluid.

Variations:

- Use this team-building exercise to highlight the value of continuous improvement.
- Can be presented as a fun team-building initiative problem — There is a computer virus and the team must punch in the correct code or the entire database will be lost!
- Variation in briefing — create a greater sense of role-play by shaping the story line: a computer virus has infected the entire network of the organization/government and your team has been flown in to disinfect it. If more than one person enters the 'restricted zone' then they are 'fried'… add as much detail as you wish to enhance the atmosphere and/or build pressure.
- Depending on the group, alter the total time to 45 minutes and allow 5 minutes of separate planning time in between each attempt.

Processing Ideas:

- What was the initial reaction of the group?
- How well did the group cope with this challenge?
- What skills did it take to be successful as a group?
- What creative solutions were suggested and how were they received?
- Did everyone listen to each other's ideas?
- What would an outside observer have seen as the strengths and weaknesses of the group?
- What roles did people play?
- What did each group member learn about him/herself as an individual?
- What key factor led to an improvement in time?
- How motivated were participants to continually improve the time after initial success at the task?

http://wilderdom.com/games/descriptions/Keypunch.html

Helium Stick

This is a classic team-building game, and an amusing exercise around which to design icebreakers.

This explanation includes games variations, and very easily improvised ideas for the stick equipment.

The basic exercise requires **all** team members to:

- support a long stick or tube — each person using one or two fingers
- lower the stick to the ground
- with no fingers losing contact with the tube.

The tendency is for the stick to rise, hence the name of the exercise, because the collective force used to keep fingers in contact with the stick is greater than the gravitational force (weight) of the stick. For this reason use a stick for the exercise that is light enough for this effect to occur, given the number of people in the team. For example a broomstick is too heavy for a team of three people, but might work for a team of ten. See the suggestions for stick types per team size below.

Other rules and guidelines:

- The stick (or any alternative item being lifted) must be rigid and not too heavy to outweigh the initial 'lift' tendency of the team size. If it's not rigid, it makes it easy for team members to maintain finger-contact.
- Start with the stick at about chest height.
- Team members can be positioned either on one or both sides of the stick — depending on stick length and team numbers.
- The team must return the stick to the starting position if any finger loses contact with the stick.
- The stick must rest on fingers — the stick cannot be grasped or pinched or held in any way.
- Typically, teams are instructed to rest the stick on the outside (nail-side or 'backs') of fingers; however, specifying a side of the finger is not critical to the activity.
- Optionally, you can instruct that a finger from each hand be used, which increases the lifting effect and the difficulty of the task. The length of the stick and the number of team members are also factors in this (i.e., two fingers per person requires a longer stick.)
- Clarify the point at which the stick is considered 'lowered to the ground' — underside of fingers or hands touching the ground is easier to monitor than actually depositing the stick onto the ground, which depending on the ground surface, can be very tricky.
- There are many ways of improvising sticks. Some people use inter-connecting tent-poles, but these are too heavy for very small teams (the gravitational force is greater than the collective lift, which makes the task too easy). Use your imagination — any rigid lightweight stick or tube will do, and if you can't improvise a stick, then other materials and shapes can be used instead, as described below.
- The activity works best with six to a dozen per team, or even more subject to having a stick long enough.
- The bigger the team, the longer the activity will take to complete successfully. This is an important point — for example given a limited time you'd be better splitting a group of twenty into two or three teams rather than run the risk of failing to complete the task, which is not great for team-building or for creating a successful mood.
- Two fingers per person (one finger each hand) creates more lifting effect and challenge but requires a longer stick than one finger per team member.
- Positioning team members on both sides of the stick enables bigger teams, but can make it more difficult for the facilitator to monitor finger-contact.

Game variations:

- Use a hula hoop instead of a stick.
- Start with the stick (or whatever else is used) at ground height, raise it to shoulder height and lower it back to the ground. The challenge is stopping it rising beyond shoulder height when it gets there.
- Issue two sticks per team — one finger for each stick — very challenging.
- Mix up the teams for different rounds to explore the dynamics of working in a new team even after all members understand the challenge and the solution.
- Just before starting the exercise, ask team members to press down hard with their outstretched fingers onto the edge of a table for 30 or 60 seconds. This confuses the brain still further and increases the tendency for the stick to rise.

Ideas for sticks and team sizes (rough guides):

- joined-together drinking straws (6 or fewer people)
- houseplant sticks (6 or fewer)
- kite struts (6 or fewer)
- rolled sheet(s) of newspaper (5-10)
- straightened-out wire coat-hangers (6-10)
- light wooden dowel rods (6-12 — cheap from most hardware stores)
- bamboo poles (5-20 people)
- hula hoop (5-20 people)

Review points examples:

- Why did the stick rise when we wanted it to go down?
- Did we anticipate the problem?
- How did we fix the problem?
- Having achieved the task with this team, was it/would it be easier/as difficult with a different team?
- How did we feel when fingers lost contact?
- What are the effects of time pressures and competition?
- How might we coach or prepare others to do this task?
- And countless other possibilities, many of which you'll see while running the exercises.

As a facilitator, use your imagination. The 'helium stick' exercise is amusing and effective in its basic format, but it can also be adapted in many ways to support many different themes related to team-work and problem-solving.

http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#team-building-games-exercises-activities